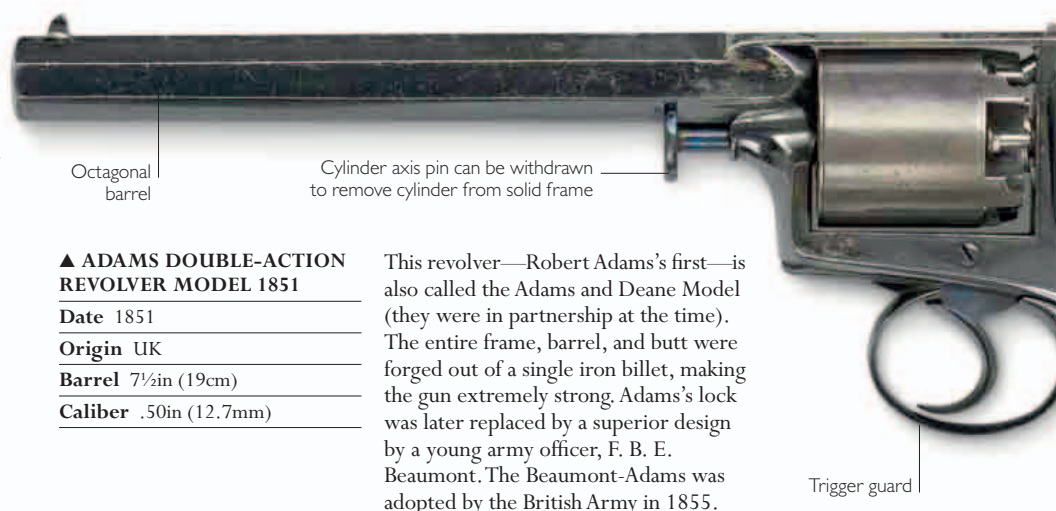


BRITISH PERCUSSION-CAP REVOLVERS

The American approach to revolver making, exemplified by the likes of Samuel Colt, sought to manufacture pistols in large numbers using machines to make interchangeable parts. In contrast, the British gun trade preferred to sustain traditional craft skills in the making of revolvers. By the mid-19th century, British companies were producing a variety of efficient revolvers, from those developed from earlier “pepperbox” (multiple-barrel) designs (see p.86), to models with sophisticated mechanisms that were either self-cocking (in which the hammer is cocked by pulling the trigger) or double-action (in which the hammer is cocked by single-action or self-cocking mechanisms).



▲ ADAMS DOUBLE-ACTION REVOLVER MODEL 1851

Date 1851

Origin UK

Barrel 7½in (19cm)

Caliber .50in (12.7mm)

This revolver—Robert Adams’s first—is also called the Adams and Deane Model (they were in partnership at the time). The entire frame, barrel, and butt were forged out of a single iron billet, making the gun extremely strong. Adams’s lock was later replaced by a superior design by a young army officer, F. B. E. Beaumont. The Beaumont-Adams was adopted by the British Army in 1855.



▲ TRANSITIONAL BAR-HAMMER REVOLVER

Date c.1855

Origin UK

Barrel 5¼in (13.5cm)

Caliber .4in (10.16mm)

Open-framed “transitional” pistols combined elements of both the pepperbox pistols they superseded and true revolvers. By the late 1850s, there was considerable demand in Britain for cylinder revolvers, but the best of them, by Colt, Deane, or Adams, were very expensive. Cheaper designs such as this open-frame example, with a bar hammer derived from a pepperbox revolver, were less satisfactory, with a tendency to discharge two cylinders at once because of the lack of partitions between the nipples.